
WESTROM GROUP PROPERTY MANAGEMENT

Dallas Fort Worth, Texas • Since 1996 • Family Owned & Operated

FREE OWNER GUIDE

How to Hire the Best Property Manager Specifically for You

A simple, no fluff playbook for Dallas Fort Worth homeowners on how to find, qualify, and pick a property manager you will actually be glad you hired, including the dirty little secrets most companies hope you never ask about.

PREPARED FOR OWNERS WHO WANT

Peace of mind, not another part time job

(817) 445-1108

westromgroup.com

The right question beats the best sales pitch

Here is the thing almost no guide will tell you. When you go shopping for a property manager, every company is going to tell you they are the best, the most responsive, the most experienced. They all say the same things. So that tells you almost nothing.

What actually protects you is not listening to better pitches. It is asking better questions, and knowing what a good answer sounds like. This guide hands you those questions, including a few that make the wrong companies very uncomfortable.

Think about how you make other important decisions. Do you pick your doctor based on a \$20 difference in the copay? Do you hire the cheapest CPA you can find? If the answer to those is no, then you are already on the right track to finding the best manager for you.

THE ONE IDEA TO REMEMBER

Hiring a property manager is not really a price decision. **It is a trust decision.** The most important things are that you genuinely like and trust the person looking after your investment, and that you protect yourself by **asking better questions and knowing what a good answer sounds like**. Everything else, including what they charge, comes after that.

What you will learn

- ✓ **How to find** the handful of managers actually worth your time
- ✓ **How to qualify** them with questions that separate pros from amateurs
- ✓ **The dirty secrets** of the industry that quietly cost owners thousands
- ✓ **How to understand** real Dallas Fort Worth pricing so no fee surprises you later
- ✓ **How to decide** which one is the best fit for you and your peace of mind

A QUICK NOTE FROM US

We wrote this to help you choose well, even if you never choose us. We have managed single family homes across the Dallas Fort Worth metroplex for 30 plus years. We would rather you ask hard questions and find the right fit than fall for the slickest website. Fair warning: people who work with us tend to end up as friends. This is a people business first.

What actually matters, in order

Most owners start with price. That is backwards. Here is the order that protects your investment and your sanity.

1

MOST IMPORTANT

"Do you trust them? Do your philosophies align?"

You will hand this person control over your largest asset and trust their judgment on your behalf. It comes down to one thing: do their philosophies on how they run a property match yours on how you want yours handled?

2

THEN THIS

"Do you like them?"

You are going to talk to these people for years, on good days and bad ones. Do you actually enjoy dealing with them? Are they responsive, warm, and easy to reach? If working together already feels like a chore, that does not improve after you sign.

3

THEN THIS

"What does it cost?"

Price matters, but do not just look at the top line charges. The poison, the pain, and the frustration live in the fine print. Someone may be one to two percent cheaper and save you twenty or thirty dollars a month, so do your research and go deeper into the full management agreement before you decide.

WHY THIS ORDER SAVES YOU MONEY

One avoided vacancy on a \$2,000 per month rental is \$2,000 back in your pocket. One avoided bad tenant can save you \$8,000 to \$10,000 in lost rent, legal fees, and repairs. A manager you trust, whose philosophy matches yours, protects you from those costs in ways a slightly lower percentage never will.

THE REAL SOURCE OF TRUST

Trust is not a vibe. It is alignment. How do you want maintenance handled, how aggressively do you want rent priced, how do you want tenants treated, how much do you want to be involved? When the company's way of doing business matches your philosophy on your property, trust follows naturally. When it does not, you will feel friction every single month no matter how nice everyone is.



Before you compare a single price, ask yourself: do this company's values and the way they handle a property actually line up with how I want mine handled?

Build a short, smart list

You do not need twenty options. You need three to five good ones, compared the same way.

- 1 Contact 3 to 5 companies, no more.** Enough to compare fees, communication, and service across Dallas Fort Worth without drowning in choices.
- 2 Verify the TREC broker license first.** In Texas, anyone managing single family rentals for compensation must hold a Real Estate Broker license. Go to trec.texas.gov, use "Verify a License Holder," and confirm the status is Active with no disciplinary history. Takes about 30 seconds and is non negotiable.
- 3 Favor local single family specialists.** There are over 250 different property management companies in the Metroplex, so this matters. Dallas and Fort Worth are different markets, and a Haslet home rents differently than one in Plano or Saginaw. You want a manager who knows your specific submarket, not just "the DFW area."
- 4 Do your homework the right way.** Reviews, ratings, and one quick phone call tell you more than any sales pitch. The next page shows you exactly how to dig. This step matters more than most owners realize.
- 5 Treat their responsiveness as a preview.** Does a live human being actually answer the phone, and can they help you? This clearly shows whether the company is available for you, for your tenants, and for prospective people looking to lease your property. This matters more than you think. How fast and clearly they answer you now is exactly how they will treat you as a paying client.

THE ONE QUESTION THAT TELLS YOU EVERYTHING

Ask them about the last owner who fired them or was not happy with their service. What happened, and how did you handle it? Their answer is a gold mine. How they talk about an unhappy client shows you, fast, whether this is a company you can like and trust.

Green lights

- ✓ Active TREC broker license you can verify
- ✓ Carries E&O insurance (\$1M is standard)
- ✓ Specializes in single family homes locally
- ✓ Answers fast, clearly, asks you good questions

Warning signs

- ✗ Vague or evasive about licensing or fees
- ✗ "We are working on" the license
- ✗ Bad reviews from actual owners (not tenants)
- ✗ Slow or generic during the sales process

How to actually vet a company

Anyone can collect five star reviews. The truth lives in the places most owners never look. Here is how the pros dig.

? *Please do a couple of minutes of homework and research before you ever get on a call with a company. A little digging up front changes every conversation that follows.*

G Google: read the worst reviews first

Do not just skim the glowing ones. Sort the reviews by **lowest rated** and read the bad reviews together with how the company responded. Their response to an upset client tells you exactly who you are dealing with and how they will treat you on a bad day.

Weight owner reviews far more than tenant reviews. Many companies incentivize tenants for five stars, a \$25 gift card or \$50 off move in, so tenant reviews get inflated. Owner reviews are much harder to earn. A single bad owner review is a huge red flag.

Y Yelp: check the suppressed reviews

Do the same worst first read on Yelp. Then scroll to the very bottom of the page to the **"not recommended" reviews** that Yelp hides by default. These suppressed reviews often contain some of the most honest and useful information you will find anywhere.

B BBB: look for complaints and resolution

Pull the Better Business Bureau report. A complaint or two is not automatically bad. What matters is whether the company actually engaged and worked to resolve them. How they handle a complaint is how they will handle yours.

THE PHONE TEST (DO THIS TODAY)

A second reminder, because it is that important: just call the company and see how things are handled. Does a real human being answer the phone? That single moment previews how you, your tenants, and your vendors will be treated every time they need something. Then ask the questions almost no one thinks of: what happens after hours or on weekends if an owner needs to reach somebody? Tenants get an emergency line, but **what happens when the owner has an after hours emergency?** You should be able to reach a real person too.

The land mines and dirty secrets of the property management industry

These are the things most companies hope you never think to ask about. None of them show up on a glossy website. All of them can cost you real money. Beware. Beware. Be aware.

Here is the mindset that protects you. A great manager will answer every one of these questions plainly, in writing, without flinching. **If a company gets vague, defensive, or starts talking fast, I like that.** It is telling you something. You do not have to accuse anyone of anything. You just have to ask, and then watch what happens.

1 The contract you cannot get out of

Many management agreements lock you into a long term that is painful or expensive to exit. Steep early termination penalties, auto renewals, and narrow written notice windows all quietly keep you paying.

The problem is simple. If it is hard to leave, the company has far less reason to keep earning your business every month. Your leverage disappears the day you sign.

3. TERM:

**** Month to Month**
No long term commitment.**

A. Primary Term: The primary term of this agreement begins and ends as follows:

Commencement Date: December 1, 2021 Expiration Date: December 31, 2021

B. Automatic Extension: Unless either party provides written notice of termination to the other party at least 30 days before the Expiration Date, this agreement will automatically extend on a monthly basis until either party terminates by providing at least 30 days written notice to the other party.

(TXR-2201) 2-1-18

Initialed for Identification by: Broker/Associate _____ and Owner _____

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WGC Management

****SAMPLE MANAGEMENT AGREEMENT****

Leasing & Management Agreement concerning: _____

C. Effective Services: If Broker determines that Broker cannot continue to effectively provide leasing and management services to Owner for any reason at any time during this agreement Broker may terminate this agreement by providing at least 30 days written notice to Owner.

D. Fees Upon Termination: At the time this agreement ends, Owner must pay Broker amounts specified in Paragraph 12.

NONE! It cost you nothing if you want to leave Westrom Group.

A real example from the Westrom Group agreement: month to month, no long term commitment, and nothing owed if you ever want to leave.

ASK BEFORE YOU SIGN

"If I am ever unhappy, exactly how do I cancel, how much notice do you need, and what does it cost me to walk away? Can you show me that clause right now?"

The two that cost the most

2

How property management companies significantly profit from your maintenance

This may be the biggest secret in the industry. Many companies are not transparent about whether, or how, they make money when your property needs maintenance. It happens in several ways, including marking up vendor invoices, adding undisclosed coordination fees, or taking kickbacks from vendors and affiliated repair companies they steer your work to.

I am not saying companies that do this are bad. I just think the transparency needs to be more upfront and clear, so you can decide with your eyes open. When a manager profits more every time something breaks, their incentives quietly stop matching yours. Beware. Beware. Be aware.

ASK BEFORE YOU SIGN

"Do you mark up any repair invoice, charge a coordination fee, or receive any payment, discount, or referral fee from the vendors you use? Will you put that answer in writing?"

3

The hidden sales commission buried in the contract

Here is one almost no owner sees coming. If you ever decide to sell the property, to your tenant, a neighbor, or a family member, the standard state default management agreement often has blanks that get filled in obligating you to pay your management company a sales commission.

On a typical home, that can be tens of thousands of dollars owed to a company simply because you happened to have a management contract with them when you sold, even if they did almost nothing to earn it.

ASK BEFORE YOU SIGN

"If I sell this property during our agreement, including to my own tenant or a family member, do I owe you any commission or fee? Show me exactly where that is addressed in the contract."

THE SIMPLE TEST

Ask for these three answers in writing. A trustworthy manager says yes immediately. Anyone who hesitates, deflects, or explains why writing it down is unnecessary has just told you everything you need to know.

What you will actually pay

This is where the smoke and mirrors live. Fee confusion sends owners into a matrix so tangled you would need an Excel spreadsheet just to figure out what you are really paying your manager.

We are not just going to tell you Westrom Group keeps it simple with three main fees. Instead, here is a large list of the many different fees various management companies across the industry have charged owners, so you know what is out there before you sign anything.

The three most common fees

- Leasing fee
- Monthly management fee
- Lease renewal fee

The two that can really hurt **WATCH CLOSELY**

- **Maintenance markup fee** (a big one)
- **Owner termination fee** (can be catastrophic and devastating)

And the list goes on **ASK IN WRITING**

- Emergency service fees
- Portal fees
- HOA fees
- Pool management fees
- Tax document fees
- Eviction protection service fees
- 12 month lease guarantee fees
- Property evaluation fees
- Posting notice fees
- Electric or utility set up and disconnect fees

MAKE THIS PART OF YOUR VETTING

Ask every company for a list, **in writing**, of all the possible fees you could be charged for their services per their contract. The list goes on and on, and the only way to compare apples to apples is to see every fee spelled out before you sign.

The cheat sheet

Print this. Sit with it after each conversation and jot down what you felt, not just what they said. The notes are where the real answer lives.

THE QUESTION THAT MATTERS	YOUR NOTES
Do I trust them? Do our philosophies on handling my property line up?	
Do I actually like them, and are they easy to reach?	
Did a live person answer the phone, and could they help?	
How did they talk about the last owner who fired them?	
What did the worst owner reviews and BBB complaints reveal?	
Can I cancel easily, and is the exit clearly explained?	
If I sell, do I owe them a commission? (Get it in writing.)	
Are they transparent about how they profit from maintenance?	
Did they give me every possible fee, in writing?	

HOW TO READ YOUR CHEAT SHEET

There is no single "best" company for everyone. If two feel close, go with the one you trust more and enjoy dealing with. A manager whose philosophy matches yours will always outperform a slightly cheaper one you have to chase. That is the whole point.

Let AI do the heavy lifting

With over 250 management companies in the Metroplex, you do not have to dig through all of them by hand. A free AI tool like ChatGPT, Claude, or Google Gemini can do the first pass for you in minutes.

- 1 Build your short list.** Ask AI to find single family property managers in your specific city or zip and summarize what owners say about each. It will surface names far faster than scrolling page after page.
- 2 Pull the reviews apart.** Paste in a company's reviews and ask AI to separate owner reviews from tenant reviews, then summarize the complaints and how the company responded. This does in seconds what would take you an hour.
- 3 Pressure test the contract.** Paste the management agreement (or the parts you are unsure about) and ask AI to flag the cancellation terms, any sale commission language, and how maintenance fees and markups are handled.

COPY AND PASTE PROMPT

"I am a rental owner choosing a property manager in [your city, Texas]. Here are reviews and the management agreement from a company I am considering. Summarize the owner reviews separately from tenant reviews, list every fee mentioned in the contract, and flag the cancellation terms, any commission owed if I sell, and how they handle maintenance markups. Then give me five sharp questions to ask them before I sign."

ONE HONEST CAUTION

AI is a brilliant research assistant, not the final word. It can be confidently wrong, so verify anything important and always read the actual contract yourself. Use it to get smart fast, then trust your own judgment and your gut on who you actually want to work with.

— ONE LAST THING

You now know what to ask

Do your homework before the call. Make sure a real person answers the phone. Ask the hard questions about the contract, the hidden sale commission, and how they profit from maintenance. Get every fee in writing. And above all, choose someone you genuinely like and trust, whose philosophy matches yours. Do that, and you will find the best manager specifically for you.

WANT A SECOND OPINION ON YOUR PROPERTY?

Get a free, no pressure rental analysis from a Dallas Fort Worth team that has managed single family homes for 30 plus years. Ask us all three dirty secret questions. We will answer every one in writing, happily. Real people, real answers, even on weekends. I dare you. I double dog dare you to text or call the owner, Jon Westrom, right now at (817) 706-0688 and see if he responds or is available.

Beware: working with us may result in friendship. We are a people business first.

(817) 445-1108

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LOCALLY OWNED

Family Operated

This guide is for general informational purposes only and is not legal or financial advice. Fee ranges, contract terms, market conditions, and licensing rules reflect general 2026 Dallas Fort Worth standards and may vary by company and change over time. Always read any management agreement in full and review it with a qualified Texas attorney before signing, and verify licensing at trec.texas.gov.